throughout the day. Parents and other caretakers have the critical role in helping children to make nutritious snack choices. Frequent snacking may result in loss of appetite during the main meal. A healthy snack should be less in size or quantity to the amount of a regular meal and taken at least 2 hours before a regular meal.



Fig 3.6 Healthy snacks

3.2.3 Nutritional problems in school-aged children

Many major risk factors for disease in developed countries (that is, blood pressure, cholesterol, overweight, obesity, low fruit and vegetable intake, and iron deficiency) are nutrition related. Provision of adequate diet during the school age period will enhance learning capacity as well as prevent adult onset diseases such as ischaemic heart disease, hypertension, some types of cancer and diabetes. In principle therefore, nutritional problems in the school aged child may carry into adulthood. Patronage for convenience and junk foods which tend to have a high fat content are a major determinant of nutritional problems. Some of the nutritional problems in this age group include the following:

Obesity

There is an increasing trend of school children being overweight and obese which is mainly attributable to reduced physical activity. Eating diets high in fat and being less physically active leads to obesity which may be a predisposition to lifelong health problems (for example, hyperlipidemia, cardiovascular problems, type 2 diabetes mellitus and obesity) in the later years.

Underweight

Many school children consume inadequate diet and so they are malnourished. Sometimes ignorance on the part of parents to know the requirements of children quantitatively or qualitatively may lead to malnutrition of children. When the child is in a hurry to go to school, he may miss breakfast or may not carry proper lunch to school or may become too tired after school activities and sleep off without taking night meal and thus skip meals. Emotional disturbances at school due to poor academic performance or problems with siblings at home may reflect on the consumption of food. Psychological factors contributing to depression or poor motivation to eat should be identified.

Constipation

Constipation in children is a common problem. A constipated child has infrequent bowel movements or hard, dry stools. Encouraging the child to make simple dietary changes such as eating more fiber-rich fruits and vegetables and drinking more fluids can go a long way toward alleviating constipation. Children may not relish vegetables and fruits particularly green leafy vegetables. Parents should make an effort to motivate the child to eat by serving fruits and vegetables in different forms.

Dental caries

Dental caries are caused by over indulging in sugary foods such as soft drinks and confectionery which predisposes school aged children to poor dental health. The risk of tooth decay is greatest with the consumption of large amounts of sticky, sugary and starchy foods that stick to the teeth (for example, sweets, sodas, lollies and candies)

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